

Victorian Selective Exam — Tips & Tricks (Final Revision)

How to use this sheet: Read it calmly in one or two sittings the day before the exam. The goal is **not** to learn new content. The goal is to remind yourself of smart ways to *attack* questions so that you never freeze on a hard one. Every technique below has a worked example so you can see exactly how it works.

The 3 Golden Rules (read these first)

1. **You are racing the clock, not the question.** Marks are equal for easy and hard questions. Bank the easy marks first, then come back for the hard ones.
 2. **A blank answer scores 0. A guess gives you a chance.** There is **no penalty for wrong answers**, so **never leave a multiple-choice question blank**. Fill in every bubble.
 3. **An eliminated option is progress.** Even if you can't find the answer, removing 1 or 2 wrong options turns a 25% guess into a 50% guess. That is worth real marks across the whole paper.
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Universal Strategies (work in every section)

1. The Two-Pass Method

Do the paper in two passes:

- **Pass 1 — Sweep for easy marks.** Answer everything you can do in under ~30 seconds. If a question looks long or confusing, mark it (a dot in the margin) and **move on immediately**.
- **Pass 2 — Return to the marked ones.** Now you have time and a calmer head for the hard ones.

Example:

In a 30-question maths section, suppose 20 are quick.

Pass 1 secures those 20 marks safely. You then have all remaining time to fight for the last 10 — instead of getting stuck on question 7 and never reaching the easy questions 25–30.

2. Eliminate, Don't Just Search

Instead of hunting for the *right* answer, hunt for *wrong* answers and cross them out.

Example:

Which number is a multiple of both 3 and 4?

- A) 14
- B) 18
- C) 24
- D) 27

- A) $14 \div 4$ isn't whole. ❌
- B) $18 \div 4$ isn't whole. ❌
- C) Only **24** survives. ✅ You found it without even checking it directly.
- D) Not even? 27 is odd → can't be a multiple of 4. ❌

3. Intelligent Guessing (when you must guess)

If you've run out of time or ideas, guess **smartly**, not randomly:

- **First eliminate** any option you *know* is wrong, then guess from what's left.
- **Pick the "middle" numbers** when totally stuck. In number questions, the correct answer is often one of the two middle values, because exam writers surround it with "too big" and "too small" traps. **Use this only when you have no other basis to choose — never to override an answer you've worked out and trust.**
- **Have a pre-chosen letter** (e.g. always C) for any question you have zero time for. This is faster than dithering and statistically as good as random.

Example:

A small fish tank on a desk holds approximately how many litres?

- A) 5
- B) 48
- C) 52
- D) 600

5 and 600 are extreme "trap" values. With no other clue, guess between **48 and 52** — the sensible middle pair.

4. The Odd-One-Out / Outlier Trick

When three options are similar and one is very different, the odd one is often a trap **or** occasionally the deliberate answer. Use it as a tie-breaker, not a rule.

Example:

Which is NOT equal to a half?

- A) 0.5
- B) 0.50
- C) $\frac{1}{2}$
- D) 0.05

A, B and C are all *the same value* (one half). The odd one out, **0.05**, stands apart → answer **D**.

5. Watch for NOT / EXCEPT / ALWAYS / NEVER

Underline these words. They flip the question.

Example:

Which of these is NOT a prime number?

If you rush, you'll pick the first prime you see and get it wrong. Underlining **NOT** reminds you to pick the non-prime.

6. Use the Answer Options as Clues ("Backsolving")

In maths/numerical questions, you can test the options instead of solving from scratch. **Start with a middle option (B or C)**. Because options are usually ordered by size, if B is too small you know the answer is higher (try C/D); if it's too big, go lower (try A). This way you rarely need to test all four.

Example:

I think of a number, multiply by 3, add 4, and get 25. What was it?

- A) 5
- B) 6
- C) 7
- D) 8

Start with B: $6 \times 3 + 4 = 22$ — too small, so go higher. Try C: $7 \times 3 + 4 = 25$.  Two checks, no algebra needed.

7. Estimate Before You Calculate

A rough estimate kills the wrong options fast and catches silly mistakes.

Example:

$312 \times 49 = ?$

Estimate: $300 \times 50 = 15,000$. Any option near 1,500 or 150,000 is a place-value trap — eliminate it instantly.

8. Manage Time with a Mental Budget

Roughly: **(time available) $\div$ (number of questions) = seconds per question.**

Example:

30 questions in 30 minutes = ~1 minute each.

If you've spent 2 minutes on one question, stop, guess, mark it, and move on. One stubborn question is never worth three easy ones.

Halfway check: when half the section's time is gone, you should be roughly halfway through the questions. If you're behind, speed up *immediately* — don't discover it at the end.

9. Fill the Bubble Carefully (and check alignment)

If you skip a question on the answer sheet, **make sure later answers don't shift up a row**. Every few questions, check that the question number matches the bubble row.

Re-read before you bubble. Glance at the last line of the question before committing. Many marks are lost by answering "what is x ?" when it actually asked "what is $2x + 3$?" — solving right but answering the wrong thing.

10. Obey the Command Word (simplify, round, exactly, at least...)

Read the *instruction* word in the question, not just the maths. Sometimes **two options are both "correct" mathematically**, but only one obeys what the question actually asked. The command word decides the winner. Common ones: *simplify, fully simplify, round, estimate, exactly, at least, no more than, in lowest terms*.

Example:

Simplify: $(2x + 4) / 2$

- A) $(2x + 4) / 2$
- B) $x + 2$
- C) $2x + 4$
- D) $x + 4$

- A) Is equal in value, but it is **not simplified** — the question said *simplify*. ❌
- B) **$x + 2$** is the fully simplified form. ✅ (Divide both terms by 2.)
- C) and D) are just wrong values. ❌

Both A and B have the *same value*, so the trap is choosing A. The word **"simplify"** is what makes **B** the only correct answer. Always let the command word break the tie.

11. Two Opposites Often Hide the Answer

When two options are **exact opposites**, the answer is often one of them — the examiner adds the opposite as a tempting distractor. Eliminate the unrelated options first, then choose between the pair **only if the passage or question supports it**.

Example:

The story's mood at the end is mostly ____.

- A) hopeful
- B) hopeless
- C) funny
- D) confusing

"hopeful" and "hopeless" are opposites, so they're worth checking first. Cross out C and D, then reread the ending to pick between **A** and **B** based on what the text says.

12. Handling "All of the Above" / "None of the Above"

- **"All of the above"** is correct only when **every** listed option is true — so confirm one or two, then quickly check the rest before choosing it.
- If you find **even one** option that is wrong, you can **immediately delete "All of the above"**.
- Find just **one** option that is true, and **"None of the above"** is gone.

Example:

Which of these is a factor of 12?

- A) 3
- B) 4
- C) 6
- D) All of the above

3, 4 and 6 *each* divide 12, so once you've checked that **all three** work, **D) All of the above** is correct. ✅
(If even one had failed, D would be wrong.)

13. The Detailed-Answer Clue (reading & verbal)

When you're genuinely unsure, the **most carefully-qualified, fully-stated** option is often correct, because the truth usually needs conditions ("...because...", "...although..."). Use it as a tie-breaker only — verify, don't blindly pick.

Example:

Passage: "Exhausted after hours of climbing, the explorer paused. Then thunder cracked overhead and the narrow path turned to slippery mud, so she turned back."

Why did the explorer turn back?

- A) She was tired.
- B) She was tired and the storm made the path too dangerous to continue.
- C) She got lost.
- D) She changed her mind.

The passage mentions **both** her tiredness *and* the dangerous storm, so the fuller option **B** matches all the evidence. A) is only half the reason; C) and D) aren't stated.

14. Grammar-Match Elimination

Options that don't fit the sentence **grammatically** (singular vs plural, verb tense, *a* vs *an*) can be crossed out instantly — even before you think about meaning.

Example:

He bought an ____ for the trip.

- A) backpack
- B) umbrella
- C) tents
- D) shoes

Two grammar rules solve it: "an" needs a word starting with a vowel sound, and "for the trip" needs a single thing (singular). - A) "an backpack" — wrong, *backpack* starts with a consonant. ❌ - B) "an umbrella" — vowel sound ✅ and singular ✅ → **correct**. - C) "an tents" / D) "an shoes" — consonant start *and* plural. ❌

(Grammar alone solved it, before even thinking about meaning.)

Reading Comprehension

Strategy

1. **Read the questions first (skim them), then the passage.** You'll read with a purpose and spot answers as you go.
2. **The answer is in the text, not in your opinion.** Choose what the passage actually says, even if you personally disagree.
3. **Eliminate "too extreme" options.** Choices with *always*, *never*, *all*, *none*, *completely* are often wrong because real passages are more cautious.
4. **Match the meaning, not just the word.** Wrong options often reuse a word from the passage but twist its meaning — a trap called a "word match."

Example — Inference

Passage: "The bridge, though old, was inspected yearly and remained perfectly safe."

What does the passage suggest about the bridge?

- A) It was dangerous because it was old.
- B) It was never inspected.
- C) It was safe despite its age.
- D) It was the oldest bridge in the world.

- A) Contradicts the text. ❌
- B) Contradicts "inspected yearly". ❌
- C) Safe despite its age. ✅
- D) "Too extreme", not stated. ❌

Example — Vocabulary in context

Cover the word and read the sentence, then slot each option in. Pick the one that keeps the meaning.

"The crowd's fervour grew as the team scored."

What does "fervour" mean here?

- A) fear
- B) boredom
- C) enthusiasm
- D) confusion

Only **enthusiasm** fits a scoring crowd. ✅

Example — Locate the line ("according to the passage")

For "according to the passage" questions, **find the exact sentence** that deals with it before you answer. The right option matches that sentence; don't rely on memory.

Question: "According to the passage, why do penguins huddle?"

Find the sentence in the text that mentions huddling, and read it carefully.

Scan for the keyword ("huddle"), reread that one sentence, then match it to an option. The answer is *in the line*, not in what you already know about penguins.

Example — Tone / feeling

Match the **author's attitude** — positive, negative, or neutral — to the option.

"The new rules were a clumsy, ill-thought-out mess that helped no one."
The author's tone is ____.

- A) admiring
- B) critical
- C) neutral
- D) excited

Words like "clumsy" and "mess" are negative, so the tone is **critical**. ✓

Don't over-infer

Pick the **smallest safe conclusion**, not the most dramatic one. If the passage says a character "frowned", that means *unhappy* — not "furious" or "planning revenge". Stay close to the text.

Mathematics

Strategy

- **Backsolve** from the options (see Universal #6) when solving is slow.
- **Estimate** to delete place-value and "way off" traps (Universal #7).
- **Units digit trick** for big multiplications — only the last digits matter.
- **Plug in easy numbers** for "in terms of" / variable questions.
- **Draw it.** A quick sketch for shapes, journeys, or fractions prevents mistakes.

Example A — Units digit shortcut

What is the units (last) digit of $23 \times 47 \times 19$?

Only multiply last digits: $3 \times 7 = 21$ ($\rightarrow 1$), then $1 \times 9 = 9$. **Units digit is 9.** No full multiplication needed.

Example B — Plug in a number

Half of a number is increased by 6. Which expression shows the result?

- A) $n/2 + 6$
- B) $(n+6)/2$
- C) $2n + 6$
- D) $n/2 - 6$

Pick $n = 10$. Half is 5, plus 6 = 11. Test options with $n = 10$: only **A** gives 11. ✓

Example C — Eliminate by a property

Which could be the perimeter of a square with whole-number sides?

- A) 18
- B) 20
- C) 21
- D) 22

A square's perimeter is $4 \times \text{side}$, so it **must be a multiple of 4**. Only **20** qualifies. ✓

Example D — Fractions vs a benchmark

Which fraction is greater than $\frac{1}{2}$?

- A) $\frac{3}{8}$
- B) $\frac{4}{9}$
- C) $\frac{5}{9}$
- D) $\frac{2}{5}$

Compare each to half (half of the bottom number): $\frac{5}{9}$ — is 5 more than half of 9 (4.5)? Yes. ✓ The others are all below their halfway point.

Example E — Backsolve a remainder question

Which number leaves remainder 2 when divided by 5, and remainder 3 when divided by 4?

- A) 18
- B) 22
- C) 27
- D) 32

Just test the options instead of solving: - C) $27 \div 5 = 5$ remainder **2** ✓, and $27 \div 4 = 6$ remainder **3** ✓ → **27**. Checking options is faster than working it out from scratch.

Example F — Percentages from 10%

Find 10% first (move the decimal one place), then scale it.

What is 30% of 60? And 15% of 60?

10% of 60 = 6. So 30% = $6 \times 3 = \mathbf{18}$. And 15% = 10% + half of 10% = $6 + 3 = \mathbf{9}$.

Example G — Average of evenly-spaced numbers

What is the average of 11, 13, 15, 17, 19?

For an evenly-spaced list, the average is just the **middle number** → **15**. No adding/dividing needed.

Example H — Even/odd (parity) check

Could $7 + 9 + 13$ equal 30?

Odd + odd + odd = **odd**, but 30 is even. So it's impossible — eliminate any even-sum option instantly. (Parity catches wrong answers without full calculation.)

Example I — Sensible units (ballpark sense)

About how tall is a classroom door?

- A) 0.2 m
- B) 2 m
- C) 20 m
- D) 200 m

A door is about head-and-arm height → **2 m**. Reject the nonsensical sizes immediately.

Example J — Ratio parts must add to the total

Share \$40 between two people in the ratio 3 : 5.

- A) \$12 and \$30
- B) \$15 and \$25
- C) \$18 and \$24
- D) \$10 and \$30

The parts must add to **\$40** *and* be in ratio 3:5. Only **B) \$15 + \$25 = \$40** works (3 parts of \$5 and 5 parts of \$5). ✅ Use the "must add to the total" check to delete wrong splits fast.

Example K — Always sketch and label

For any angle, shape, or geometry problem, **draw a quick sketch even if one is given**, and label every value you know. Marking the unknowns as letters often makes the next step obvious.

Two angles sit on a straight line. One is 110° . What is the other?

Sketch the straight line and the two angles meeting on it. Label the known one 110° and the unknown x . Angles on a straight line add to 180° , so $x = 180 - 110 = 70^\circ$. The labelled sketch makes the rule jump out.

Example L — Reverse percentage (work backwards)

When a question gives the **final** amount after a percentage change and asks for the **original**, divide by the multiplier — don't multiply by its "opposite".

A price rose by 20% to reach \$120. What was the original price?

The trap is $120 \times 0.80 = \$96$. ❌ Correct: $\text{original} \times 1.2 = 120$, so $\text{original} = 120 \div 1.2 = \100 . ✅ **Rule:** to undo a +20% rise, **divide by 1.2**; to undo a -20% drop, **divide by 0.8**.

Example M — LCM / HCF by listing (fast for small numbers)

Under time pressure, a quick list often beats prime factorisation.

Find the LCM of 6 and 8.

List multiples of the **larger** number: 8, 16, **24**, ... and stop at the first one also divisible by 6 → **LCM = 24**. For the **HCF**, list the factors of each and take the biggest shared one (e.g. 12 and 18 share 1, 2, 3, **6** → HCF = 6).

Example N — Symmetry: fold and match

For reflection or line-of-symmetry questions, imagine **folding the shape along the line** — the two halves must land exactly on top of each other.

Is the dashed line a line of symmetry?

Picture folding along the dashed line. If every point on one side lands on a matching point on the other, it **is** a line of symmetry; if any part sticks out, it isn't. This is faster and surer than counting squares.

Numerical Reasoning

This section is about **patterns, sequences, and logic with numbers** — often under tight time.

Strategy

- **Look at the gaps** between numbers first (differences), then differences of differences.
- **Check for $\times$, $\div$, or alternating rules** if adding/subtracting doesn't fit.
- For "odd one out", **find the rule the majority share**, then spot who breaks it.
- **Estimate / eliminate** rather than computing every option fully.

Example A — Sequence

2, 6, 12, 20, 30, ?

Differences: 4, 6, 8, 10 → next difference 12. So $30 + 12 = 42$.

Example B — Alternating pattern

5, 50, 6, 60, 7, ?

The pattern alternates "number" then "number $\times 10$ ": after 7 comes **70**.

Example C — Odd one out

Which doesn't belong: 9, 16, 24, 25, 36?

9, 16, 25, 36 are perfect squares (3^2 , 4^2 , 5^2 , 6^2). **24** is the odd one out.

Example D — Function machine

IN $\rightarrow \times 3 \rightarrow -1 \rightarrow$ OUT. If OUT is 14, what was IN?

Work backwards: $14 + 1 = 15$, $15 \div 3 = 5$. (Reverse the steps and reverse the operations.)

Example E — Two-step rule ($\times$ then $+$)

When single differences don't fit, try a **two-step rule** like " $\times 2$ then $+1$ ", repeated.

1, 3, 7, 15, 31, ?

Each term is **$\times 2$ then $+1$** : $31 \times 2 + 1 = 63$. (Also spot it as "double the gap each time": gaps are 2, 4, 8, 16 $\rightarrow$ next gap 32 $\rightarrow 31 + 32 = 63$.)

Verbal Reasoning

This tests word logic: analogies, codes, odd-one-out, letter patterns, and word relationships.

Strategy

- For analogies, say the relationship out loud as a sentence, then apply it to the second pair.
- For letter/number codes, line up the alphabet and count the "jump."
- For odd-one-out, find the category the majority belong to.

- **Eliminate** options that don't fit the relationship at all.

Example A — Analogy

Kitten is to Cat as Puppy is to ____?

Say it: "A kitten is a baby cat." So a puppy is a baby **dog**. ✅ **Keep the direction the same:** apply "puppy is a baby ", **not** "is the parent of a puppy". Under pressure it's easy to flip an analogy backwards and pick the wrong word.

Example B — Letter code

If CAT is coded as DBU, what is DOG?

Each letter moves **+1** in the alphabet (C→D, A→B, T→U). So D→E, O→P, G→H = **EPH**.

Example C — Odd one out (words)

rose, tulip, oak, daisy

Three are flowers; **oak** is a tree. Odd one out = oak.

Example D — Hidden word

A small word is hidden across the join of two words.

In "the bear under the tree growled", a 3-letter word meaning "move fast" hides where "bear" meets "under". Find it.

Read across the gap: "bear **under**" → the letters spell **run**. Practise scanning the place where two words meet to find the hidden word (a body part, animal, action, or number).

Example E — Closest in meaning (synonyms)

Which word is closest in meaning to "rapid"?

- A) slow
- B) quick
- C) loud
- D) wide

Eliminate opposites (slow) and unrelated (loud, wide). **Quick**. ✅

Example F — Eliminate the matching pair (clever synonym trick)

A "same meaning" question has **exactly one** correct answer. So if two options mean the **same as each other**, they cancel out — if one were right, the other would have to be too. Treat both as unlikely and focus on the remaining words, which are often the unfamiliar ones. (If you know the target word well, still double-check before crossing a pair out.)

Which word is closest in meaning to GARRULOUS?

- A) quiet
- B) silent
- C) loquacious
- D) taciturn

- A) and B) "quiet" and "silent" mean the **same as each other** → only one answer is allowed, so **both are out. ✖✖** (You don't even need to know what *garrulous* means yet!)
- That leaves C) and D) — the two unfamiliar words. Now it's a 50/50, far better than a blind guess.
- *Garrulous* means "talkative". **Loquacious** also means talkative. ✔️ (*Taciturn* is the opposite — it means "saying little".)

Why this works: the trick lets you delete two options using pure logic, *before* you even know the hard word. Even if you have to guess between the last two, you've doubled your odds.

Example G — Number the alphabet

For letter codes and "which letter comes next", lightly **write A=1, B=2 ... Z=26** in the margin. Counting jumps becomes simple arithmetic.

Which letter is exactly halfway between D and P?

D = 4, P = 16. Halfway = $(4 + 16) \div 2 = 10$ → the 10th letter = **J**. Numbering removes the guesswork.

Example H — Know the analogy types

Most analogies are one of these relationships. Run through the list to name the link, then apply it:

Common analogy types:

- Opposite (hot : cold)
- Part-to-whole (finger : hand)
- Cause-effect (rain : flood)
- Category (rose : flower)
- Degree (warm : hot)

Example: "finger is to hand as petal is to ____?" The link is *part-to-whole*, so the answer is **flower**. ✔️
Naming the type stops you picking a word that's merely "related".

Writing (the short tips that matter most under time pressure)

You can't "guess" in writing, but you can use a reliable structure so you never stare at a blank page.

Strategy

1. **Spend the first 2–3 minutes planning** (a quick list of 3 ideas/paragraphs). Planning saves time overall and stops you rambling.
2. **Use a clear structure:** - *Persuasive*: Introduction (your position) → 3 reasons (one per paragraph, each with an example) → Conclusion (restate position). - *Creative/Narrative*: Setting → problem → build-up → climax → resolution.
3. **Strong opening line.** A question, a sound, or a bold statement grabs the marker.
4. **Show, don't tell.** "Her hands trembled" is better than "She was scared."
5. **Leave 2 minutes to proofread** for capital letters, full stops, and spelling.
6. **Spot the genre from the prompt wording.** "Imagine / write a story" = creative; "convince / should / argue" = persuasive. Writing the wrong type costs marks even if the writing is good.
7. **Keep a bank of 3 reusable examples** ready — e.g. a historical figure, a personal anecdote, and a science fact. You can bend almost any persuasive topic to use them, saving thinking time.
8. **Vary sentence length.** A short, punchy sentence after a long one reads well. Like this.
9. **Aim for the suggested length** if one is given. Too short looks underdeveloped; too long risks rushing the ending and making careless mistakes.

Example — Opening lines

Persuasive: "Should children have homework every night? The answer is a clear no – and here's why."

Narrative: "The door creaked open, but no one was supposed to be home."

A strong first line earns the marker's attention immediately — a question for persuasive, a hook of tension for narrative.

Example — Genre cue spotting

Prompt 1: "Should students wear school uniforms? Write to convince the reader."

Prompt 2: "Write a story that begins: 'The lights went out...'"

Prompt 1 says "convince" → **persuasive** (position + reasons). Prompt 2 says "story" → **creative/narrative** (setting → problem → climax → resolution). Match the structure to the cue.

Exam-Day Mindset & Mechanics

Small habits that protect your marks when the pressure is on:

- **The "skip and breathe" reset.** If two hard questions in a row rattle you, deliberately do an easy one next to rebuild confidence before returning to the hard ones.
- **"Park" nagging thoughts.** If a worry — or a question you weren't sure about — keeps pulling at you, tell yourself "it's parked, I'll deal with it later" and bring your attention back to the question in front of you. It's a real focus technique, not just a saying.
- **Start each section fresh.** If one section felt hard, it's over — don't let it sour the next one. Every section is a clean slate of marks, so reset and go again.
- **Use the break well.** If there's a break between sections, take it properly: go to the restroom even if you don't feel desperate (it's easy to forget, then get distracted later), have a drink of water, and take a few slow breaths. Staying calm and hydrated keeps your concentration sharp.
- **Don't change answers without a reason.** Your first instinct is usually right — only change it if you spot a clear, specific mistake, not just a nervous feeling.
- **Keep the eraser light and clean.** Half-erased or smudged bubbles can be misread by the marking scanner. Rub out fully and fill the new bubble darkly.
- **Watch for double negatives.** "Not uncommon" means **common**; "not unlike" means **similar**. Untangle them slowly.

Example — double negative:

The result was "not unexpected".

"not" + "unexpected" cancel out → it means the result **was expected**. Read these phrases twice.

The Night Before & The Morning Of

- **Tonight:** read this sheet once, pack pencils/eraser, sleep early. **No new topics.**
- **In the morning:** eat a good breakfast — your brain genuinely works better when it's fuelled.
- **In the exam:**
 - Read each instruction line slowly *once* — they tell you how many to choose and the time.
 - Do Pass 1 (easy marks), then Pass 2 (hard ones).
 - **Never leave a multiple-choice blank** — eliminate, then guess.
 - If your mind goes blank, take one slow breath, do the next easy question, and come back.

You already know enough. These tricks just help you show it. Stay calm, keep moving, and bank every mark you can. Good luck! 🍀